A4 Research Question - Revised Version

MSCD Pre-Thesis - Fall 2026

Part 1. The three steps

Step 1: Topic

I am studying an ordinary day in the digital life of adult Chinese Gen Z. Paying, communicating, travelling, learning, and working already pass through super apps. Generative AI now joins thinking and knowledge work, while emerging agents can use tools and complete longer tasks. My topic is how this layered digital environment shapes what young adults do, notice, and treat as normal.

Step 2: Question

I want to find out whether participants notice these influences when they move through concrete scenes from their day. I want to learn how they explain the roles that they and the systems play now, which parts feel useful or unavoidable, and what roles they would prefer. The study will leave room for mixed and changing views rather than asking participants to support one position about technology.

Step 3: Significance

I want to help design researchers understand the accumulated relationship between a person and many connected digital systems across a day, rather than only one moment of human-AI collaboration. The study can produce a situated map of current and preferred roles among adult Chinese Gen Z, show where tension or uncertainty appears, and record how provocative design probes make these experiences easier to discuss. This may give later designers and researchers clearer questions to ask as AI becomes part of everyday infrastructure.

Part 2. Canvas discussion post

Topic: An Ordinary Day, Already Designed: Chinese Gen Z Between Super Apps and Agentic AI

My research is about an ordinary day in the digital life of adult Chinese Gen Z. Paying, communicating, travelling, learning, and working already pass through super apps and platform accounts. Generative-AI chat now joins searching, writing, and thinking. Emerging AI agents may go further by using tools, working for longer periods, and completing actions. I am interested in the accumulated relationship across a day: what these systems make possible, what they quietly make normal, and what role is left for the person.

How do adult Chinese Gen Z notice and explain the ways digital infrastructures and emerging AI shape an ordinary day in their lives, and what current and preferred roles do they describe for themselves and these systems?

This question comes from a feeling I have difficulty explaining. I usually think of an app as a tool that I choose to use. However, I also learn to live in the way the tool expects. I carry my phone because payment, communication, travel, and access to services may depend on it. I use memes and text to express myself partly because these forms fit the platforms where my relationships happen. I may use AI to develop an idea and later feel unsure about how much of the thinking was mine. These are small moments, but together they shape a way of living.

The question feels urgent because two changes are happening at the same time. China already has mature digital platforms that many young adults cannot easily leave without a practical or social cost. Now AI functions are entering these platforms. I have recently seen users respond to new WeChat AI features with basic questions: Why is this here? What information can it read? Can I refuse or turn it off? Whether every fear is technically correct is not the only issue. The reaction shows that an AI layer can enter an important everyday system before people understand what role it will have.

At the same time, AI is moving beyond a chat box. Agents can work through several steps, call tools, operate for longer periods, and sometimes work in parallel. My third probe only studies an early and limited form of this change. The technology is developing faster than the language many people have for discussing how they want to live with it.

Research on human-technology relationships already includes agency, trust, black boxes, explainability, human-AI collaboration, and studies in areas such as writing, education, decision-making, and robotics. I therefore do not claim that studying “roles” is new. The specific contribution of my project is its unit of inquiry and its context. I follow the accumulated relationship across an ordinary day instead of isolating one task. I study the same group across three connected arrangements: platforms shaping daily routines, AI participating in knowledge-making, and agents beginning to act. I also compare the roles participants experience now with the roles they would prefer.

I will use Research through Design and develop three connected probes. Each probe cuts into one part of the same larger relationship. *Evil PM Simulator* explores how platform decisions become everyday conditions. *Epistemic Illusion* explores what happens when AI participates in forming knowledge. *Cyber-Utopia Persona Quiz* explores how people imagine a system acting for them as situations become more personal or uncertain. The sessions will be semi-structured. Participants can describe what they

notice, disagree with the probe, connect it to their own lives, and revise their view.

The study will not produce a universal rule for all users. Its main outcome will be a situated account of how adult Chinese Gen Z describe dependence, assistance, discomfort, and preferred relationships with digital systems. I expect to produce a map of role tensions across a day, patterns that compare current and preferred roles, and an annotated portfolio of the three probes. For designers, this can show which parts of a human-system relationship people want to understand, question, or renegotiate. For later researchers, it can provide a starting point for comparison as agentic technology develops.

Part 3. The sharper thesis structure

The unit of inquiry

The study does not claim to cover every area of Chinese Gen Z life. Its unit of inquiry is the accumulated relationship with digital systems across an ordinary day.

The three analytical cuts

1. **Everyday conditions:** how platform decisions become routines, requirements, and normal expectations.
2. **Knowledge-making:** how AI participates in searching, interpreting, writing, and judging.
3. **Acting:** how a system moves from giving an answer to carrying out steps for a person.

What the study compares

- What participants notice and do not notice.
- The roles they think people and systems currently play.
- What feels helpful, unavoidable, uncomfortable, or unacceptable.
- The roles they would prefer in the same situation.
- How their position changes across the three probes.

What remains after the probes

- A situated map of role tensions across an ordinary day.
- Patterns showing gaps between current and preferred roles.
- An annotated portfolio explaining what each probe revealed and failed to reveal.
- Design questions for systems that enter everyday infrastructure.